powers to unite against him, and his empire collapsed a decade after he crowned himself emperor.

Indeed, in the long term, Napoleon's victories ensured the permanent decline of France. For centuries, France was Europe's leading geopolitical power, largely because neither Italy nor Germany existed as a unified political entity. Italy was a hodgepodge of dozens of warring city-states, feudal principalities and church territories. Germany was an even more bizarre jigsaw puzzle divided into more than a thousand independent polities, loosely held together under the theoretical suzerainty of the Holy Roman Empire of the German Nation.[24] In 1789, the prospect of a German or Italian invasion of France was simply unthinkable, because there was no such thing as a German or Italian army.

As Napoleon expanded his empire into central Europe and the Italian peninsula, he liquidated the Holy Roman Empire in 1806, amalgamated many of the smaller German and Italian principalities into larger territorial blocs, created a German Confederation of the Rhine and a Kingdom of Italy, and sought to unify these territories under his dynastic rule. His victorious armies also spread the ideals of modern nationalism and popular sovereignty into the German and Italian lands. Napoleon thought all this would make his empire stronger. In fact, by breaking up traditional structures and giving Germans and Italians a taste of national consolidation, Napoleon inadvertently laid the foundations for the ultimate unification of Germany (1866–71) and of Italy (1848–71). These twin processes of national unification were sealed by the German victory over France in the Franco-Prussian War of 1870–71. Faced with two newly unified and fervently nationalistic powers on its eastern border, France never regained its position of dominance.

A more recent example of military victory leading to political defeat was provided by the American invasion of Iraq in 2003. The Americans won every major military engagement, but failed to achieve any of their long-term political aims. Their military victory didn't establish a friendly regime in Iraq or a favourable geopolitical order in the Middle East. The real winner of the war was Iran. American military victory turned Iraq from Iran's traditional foe into Iran's vassal, thereby greatly weakening the American position in the Middle East while making Iran the regional hegemon.[25]